

Rakszawa, Wisconsin

Why Does Bober Drink Beer? Six Centuries, One Wall, and a Can That Lies About Where It
Comes From

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2026

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The Light Goes Flat at Half Past Three

Eighth Place, and Falling

What the Dues Did Not Take, the Vodka Took

A Prize Nobody Won, A Muse Nobody Found

Ten Minutes Nobody Pays For

RAKSZAWA WISCONSIN

An abstract painting in bold colors (blue, red, yellow, green) is applied to a grey concrete wall. The paint is thick and textured, with significant drips running down the wall. In the bottom right corner, a wooden shelf holds a can of 'Blue Bull' beer, a paint roller, and a paintbrush.

WHY DOES BOBER DRINK BEER

Rakszawa, Wisconsin

Why Does Bober Drink Beer?

Six Centuries, One Wall, and a Can That Lies About Where It Comes From

Built from the public work of

Kate Fox -- social anthropologist; drunken behaviour is a cultural script, not a chemical

Mark Lawrence Schrad -- political scientist; the state was always the pusher

Ziemowit Szczerek -- Polish gonzo writer; the view from inside the country

and from Jerzy Pilch, Wojciech Smarzowski, Kacper Poblocki, Wladyslaw Reymont, the Wielki słownik języka polskiego of the Polish Academy of Sciences, and the records of a brewery at Rakszawa, Podkarpackie.

August 2026

The Light Goes Flat at Half Past Three

Fifteen forty. Bober is forty feet up in a steel basket, and the can is sitting on the rail by his left knee, unopened.

The wall behind him is two-thirds finished. Below the basket there is a pallet of paint, a generator, a man in a hard hat who is legally responsible for the machine Bober is standing in, and a strip of pavement taped off with the kind of plastic ribbon that is the only ribbon in this book that ever meant anything. Bober has been up here since half past seven. His hands are the colour of the wall. He has not opened the can.

This is the moment the whole book is about, so let us not spend it badly.

A lesser book gives you an anecdote here. A lesser book tells you that the Polish painter reached for a beer, and then does a little sad music about the Polish painter reaching for a beer, and the reader nods, because everyone already knows the tune. The tune is the enemy. The tune arrives before the facts do, it explains everything, and it is wrong -- Chapter 2 will take a table of numbers to it and leave nothing standing.

So before anybody opens anything, here is the apparatus. Every number in it is real.

The wall has a temperature

Bober is not painting a picture. He is applying an industrial coating to the exterior of a residential building, and the coating has opinions.

Acrylic facade paint wants to go on between plus 10 and plus 30 degrees Celsius. Silicone facade paint is the more forgiving of the two and will work down to plus 5. Below that, nothing goes on the wall that you would want to see next spring. Rain is out. Wind is out, because wind takes the spray and gives it to somebody's parked car. Frost is out. High humidity is out. Harsh direct sun is also out, which surprises people who assume the enemy is only cold: sun flashes the surface dry before the film has knitted, and you get a wall that looks finished and is not.

Add those constraints together across a Polish year and you get an exterior painting season of roughly six to seven months. Half the calendar is simply unavailable. Not difficult -- unavailable. The wall does not care about the festival's programme, the grant's reporting deadline, or the fact that the artist is at the height of his powers in February.

Then there is the volume. A gable end of a thousand square metres takes something like 170 to 330 litres of base paint to get two coats on, and that is before a single can of anything with a colour in it is touched. Before the image. Before the thing anyone photographs. Two or three bathtubs of white, lifted, hauled, decanted, rolled, and then repeated, because one coat is not a coat.

Scale is the point. When you stand on the pavement and look up at a mural, you are looking at a painting. When you stand in the basket, you are looking at a surface, and the surface is winning.

The certificate

The basket has a name: podnosnik koszowy. A boom lift. On a tall building it is not a preference, it is the only economic option, because scaffolding a twelve-storey gable to paint it costs more than the painting.

The man operating the lift must hold UDT certification. Not "should." Must. There is a state technical inspection office, there is a certificate, there is a human being who has passed an examination in order to raise a painter to the height at which the painter can be an artist. Somebody in this arrangement holds a formal qualification, and it is not the one with paint in his eyebrows.

Sit with that for a second, because it is the first joke this book actually believes in. The romantic account of the muralist has him alone with the wall, the city, and his demons. The real account has him standing in a certified machine driven by a certified operator inside a taped-off exclusion zone, subject to a weather window, applying a product with a datasheet. The demons, if they show up, have to clear it with the site.

How long a wall takes

Fifty to a hundred square metres runs four to ten days. That is a modest wall -- a single gable of a low block, the sort of thing a passer-by processes in a second and a half.

Bigger, then. In Lodz in October 2021, a twenty-four-storey wall over seventy metres high took eight painters more than two weeks. Eight. More than two weeks. And in the same city in 2013, the Chilean painter Inti did an eleven-storey wall over eleven days, alone.

Eleven days. Alone. On a machine. In the weather.

Whatever you think is happening to a person's attention on day nine of eleven at altitude, it is not the thing that happens to a person's attention in a studio. There is no back of the room to walk to. You cannot step away from the work, because the work is eleven storeys tall and you are strapped to it. To see what you have done, you have to descend, cross the

road, turn round, look, cross back, and go up again -- which costs minutes and daylight, so you ration it, so you spend most of the day painting something you cannot see.

This is the physical fact that the entire mythology of the drinking artist has never had to account for. It is a job. It has a lift, an operator, a datasheet, a window, and a clock.

The eye goes before the arm

Here is why the can is still shut at half past three and why it will not be shut at twenty to four.

Bober has been mixing and matching colour on a vertical surface in daylight for eight hours. The arm is fine. The arm could go until dark. The eye is what fails, and it fails in a specific, boring, physical way: the low sun comes round, the light loses its bite, and the colours on the wall stop being distinguishable from one another. Everything goes slightly the same. The shadow he mixed at eleven and the shadow he is mixing now are two different shadows that currently look like one shadow, and he will only find out which at ten past nine tomorrow morning, on somebody else's daylight.

A painter can work with a tired arm. A painter cannot work with a lying eye. Every mark laid down after the light flattens is a mark that has a decent chance of having to come off tomorrow -- and coming off, on a facade, means sanding back and repainting a section you already paid for twice.

So the working day does not end when Bober is finished. It ends when the light stops telling the truth. That moment arrives in the middle of the afternoon, and it arrives whether or not he is ready, whether or not the

section is complete, whether or not the festival wants the wall done by Friday.

Now open the can.

It is a beer. It cost about as much as a bread roll. It is 4.7 percent, in a 500 millilitre bottle or a can with a blue ribbon printed on it, and the ribbon is a lie of such magnificent construction that it gets its own chapter later. He drinks it slowly, because it is the only thing today he is permitted to do slowly.

The comedy is in the mismatch. Certified operator, industrial coating, thirty-metre boom, exclusion zone, six-month season, 330 litres of base, eight painters and two weeks -- and at the top of this entire apparatus, the object that ends the working day is a supermarket lager that a Polish beer site once reviewed and gave two out of ten.

What the beer is not doing

Note the time again, because it does more work than any adjective could.

It is not the morning. This matters, and the book will keep insisting on it. Bober does not drink to get up the ladder, does not drink to steady the hand at eight, does not need a klin to start. The first one lands after eight hours of work, at the precise point in the day when the specific faculty his trade depends on has stopped functioning. It arrives at the end of the useful part of the day, not the beginning of it.

That timing changes the question completely. "Why does Bober drink beer?" sounds like a question about a man's character. Timed to the light, it becomes a question about a working day: what is the object that tells a man on a lift that the day's judgement is finished, and why does it have to be an object at all? Nothing else up there can say it. The wall cannot say it

-- the wall is two-thirds done and looks reproachful in any light. The client cannot say it. The forecast, which will be worse tomorrow, definitely cannot say it.

There is a Polish line that convicts the can from the other direction, and it is the best five words anyone has ever written on the subject. In Smarzowski's WESELE, a character says of vodka: "Poniewierac ma, a nie smakowac." It is meant to knock you about, not to taste good.

That is a whole philosophy, and it has no room in it for what Bober is holding. A 4.7 percent lager, one of them, sipped over ten minutes at altitude, is not knocking anybody about. By the strictest available Polish theory of drinking, this barely counts as drinking. The folk couplet makes the same distinction and even ranks it: "Wszak od wodki rozum krotki, a od piwa glowia sie kiwa." From vodka, short wits; from beer, a nodding head. Two substances, two verdicts, and Bober is holding the second one -- the one that gets you a nodding head, not a short wit.

Anyone who wants to explain this man with the phrase "Poles drink" now has to explain why he is drinking the wrong thing, at the wrong hour, in the wrong quantity, in a country the numbers say is eighth and falling.

The vocabulary rule, stated once

There is a Polish phrase that will run under the rest of this book: przy piwie. Over a beer. It is the standard frame for the conversation where somebody finally says what they think -- the politics, the grievance, the thing that could not be said in the meeting. Not at a beer, not with a beer. Over one. The beer is the setting, the licence and the alibi in a single preposition.

Here is the discipline, and it is worth stating in the first chapter so that nobody has to wonder later. Every Polish word in this book is one that a dictionary, a printed source or a named speaker will stand behind. Where the research could not confirm a phrase, the phrase is absent, however good it would have sounded. A book about a stereotype cannot afford to run on invented folklore, because invented folklore is exactly the machinery that built the stereotype. If it is not verified, it is not here.

In every normal country

Ziemowit Szczerek, who has spent a career on the ugly and specific truth of Polish public space, opens a passage in his novel *Siódemka* with this: "W każdym normalnym kraju, od tego zaczniemy, nie używa się zwrotu 'w każdym normalnym kraju'." In every normal country, let's start here, nobody uses the phrase "in every normal country."

That sentence is this book's licence. The instinct to measure yourself against an imagined normal country is the same instinct that answers a question about one man on a lift with a fact about a nation. In every normal country a man has a beer after work. In every normal country nobody would write a book about it. Both of those sentences are ways of not looking at the thing.

So we are going to look at the thing, and we are going to take a stupid-sounding question with more seriousness than it has ever been shown, on the grounds that this is the only way anybody finds out anything.

Here is what the question has to survive.

It has to survive the numbers, which say Poland is eighth in Europe and falling, that the champion of Central Europe is Czechia by two full litres, and that the country in the stereotype has been quietly turning into a

beer country for thirty years. That is the next chapter, and it removes national character from the list of available answers.

Then it has to survive the history, which will show that nobody in Poland ever chose this supply -- that a landlord held the legal right to make the alcohol, the monopoly on selling it, and the power to compel a household to buy a quota, with the unbought remainder dumped in front of the house and charged for. Six centuries of somebody else building the reflex, and a modern parliament still adjusting the dial.

Then it has to survive the can itself, which is a Polish product wearing an American costume, decorated with a prize that was never awarded, and endorsed by a science that did not replicate.

And when all four of those answers have been taken away, something will still be true at twenty to four in the afternoon, forty feet up, with the light going flat and the wall two-thirds finished.

The apparatus is certified. The paint has a datasheet. The season is six months. The operator holds a licence to lift him.

Nobody has issued a certificate for stopping. That is what the can is for, and it takes four more chapters to prove it.

Eighth Place, and Falling

Eighth.

That is the whole chapter, and everything after this sentence is just the eighth place being carried up four flights of stairs and set down gently in front of you so you can see it is real. Poland is eighth in Europe for alcohol consumption. Not first. Not second. Not, as roughly every bar conversation in the English-speaking world has assumed since about 1981, so far out in front that the second-place country needs a telescope. Eighth. Behind Romania, Latvia, Portugal, Czechia, Bulgaria, Spain and Austria, in that order, with Hungary, Lithuania and France breathing on the back of its neck.

The joke you were going to make does not survive the table. Let us put the table on the page and watch it die.

The Table

WHO Global Health Observatory, indicator SDG 3.5.2, total alcohol per capita consumption among adults aged fifteen and over, three-year average, 2024 figures, in litres of pure ethanol:

Romania 17.07. Latvia 14.18. Portugal 13.75. Czechia 13.52. Bulgaria 13.25. Spain 12.07. Austria 11.60. **Poland 11.51.** Hungary 11.36. Lithuania 11.23. France 11.19. Germany 10.93. Ireland 10.27.

Romania beats Poland by 5.56 litres of pure alcohol per adult per year. That is not a rounding error, that is a rout. Czechia -- Central Europe's actual champion, a country whose national self-image is a beer glass with

a head on it and which has the receipts to back it -- beats Poland by 2.01. Portugal, a nation the drunken-Pole joke has never once considered, is 2.24 litres ahead and doing it mostly in wine, in the sun, with lunch.

And look where the joke's usual straight man ends up. Germany, the country invoked in every comparison as the sensible one, the one with the engineering and the punctuality, is 10.93. Poland is 11.51. The gap is 0.58 litres a year. That is about one and a half glasses of wine. Twelve months of national character, and the difference between the stereotype and its own control group is a glass and a half of wine.

If the drunken Pole is a real category of person, he is beaten annually by a Romanian, a Latvian, a Portuguese, a Czech, a Bulgarian, a Spaniard and an Austrian, and he is barely holding off a Hungarian, a Lithuanian and a Frenchman. He is a mid-table finisher. He is the guy who comes eighth and is quietly pleased not to have come tenth.

Nobody makes jokes about the drunken Latvian. Latvia is 14.18.

And Falling

Eighth would be a bad enough result for the stereotype if it were stable. It is not stable. It is going down.

WHO's recorded figure for Poland -- the alcohol that legally exists, that was made and taxed and rung through a till -- peaked in the modern era at 10.99 in 2019. By 2023 it was 10.00. In 2024 it was 9.79. Across the whole decade from 2013 to 2023 the number moved from 10.81 to 10.00. That is a country drinking less, year after year, through a period in which the world was mostly finding new reasons to drink more.

The beer market agrees. Polish beer went from 41 million hectolitres in 2018 to 34.6 million in 2024, a collapse the trade press described as the

equivalent of six large breweries closing. Beer in natural litres per head peaked at 100.5 in 2018 and is now around 85.8. The industry is not sitting on a national vice, it is sitting on a shrinking one, watching fifteen litres a head walk out the door and not come back.

So the stereotype is wrong about the level and wrong about the direction. It describes a country that is drinking more than everyone else and getting worse, and the country in question is drinking less than seven other countries and getting better. As predictions go, this is the weather forecast calling for a heatwave on a wall that will not take paint below plus ten.

Two Honest Corrections, Because a Debunking That Cheats Is Just a Second Lie

Two things have to be said here or this chapter is no better than the thing it is attacking.

First: this is not the highest Polish drinking has ever been, and anyone telling you the country is at some unprecedented historical summit is selling something. The all-time recorded peak was 1981, at 11.21 -- higher than 2019's 10.99 -- and then martial law arrived and the figure fell off a cliff to 8.54 in 1982, for reasons that had nothing to do with anybody's willpower and everything to do with tanks. Hold that thought. It comes back in the next chapter with a vengeance.

Second: there are two numbers for Polish drinking and they must never be mixed. The Polish domestic series, from GUS and KCPU, counts registered sales across the whole population, infants included, and gives 8.8 litres for 2024. WHO counts adults from fifteen up and adds an estimate for unrecorded alcohol, and gives 9.79 recorded, 11.51 total.

Both are correct. They are measuring different things with different denominators. Every alarmist headline about Polish drinking that you have ever read was built by taking the big number from one column and the scary adjective from another, and the honest version of this argument does not get to do that either. Eleven point five one is the number that puts Poland eighth in Europe. Eight point eight is the number that describes the average Polish resident, newborns and abstainers and grandmothers included. Neither of them is first place.

The domestic series, incidentally, begins in 1992. If somebody quotes you a Polish government figure for 1990, they have invented it. It does not exist.

Bober Is Not Even Drinking Vodka

Here is where the stereotype stops being merely wrong about quantity and starts being wrong about the object.

The joke is always vodka. It is a shot glass, a bottle on a table, something clear and forty percent, and a shudder. That picture was defensible once. In 1990, spirits were 5.06 litres of Poland's per-adult intake, sixty-two percent of everything drunk. Beer was 2.02 litres, twenty-four point eight percent. The country really was, by volume of pure alcohol, a vodka country, and the cartoon had a nation behind it.

By 2000, spirits were down to 2.47 litres and 30.8 percent. Beer was up to 3.78 and 47.1 percent. In one decade, the thing the joke was about lost half its share.

By 2024, spirits have come back up to 3.99 litres and 40.8 percent -- and that partial return is not a story about character either, it is a story about a tax cut, which is Chapter 3's business -- but beer is now 5.04 litres

and 51.5 percent. Beer, in natural litres per head, went from 38.6 in 1992 to 100.5 at the 2018 peak. Poland spent thirty years quietly turning into a beer country while the rest of the world kept telling the vodka joke.

Which brings us up the wall. Bober is forty feet up on a boom lift with a wall two-thirds finished and the light going flat, and in his hand is a five hundred millilitre pale lager at 4.7 percent. Not a setka. Not a malpka. Not a bottle of anything clear. He is holding the majority beverage of a mid-table European country, and he is holding it in the exact proportion the national statistics predict.

The folk couplet knew the difference before the statisticians did. *Wszak od wodka rozum krotki, a od piwa glowa sie kiwa*. From vodka, short wits; from beer, a nodding head. Two substances, two consequences, one couplet, and the joke about Poland has spent forty years insisting on the first half while the country migrated into the second.

The Costume, Worn by the People It Supposedly Describes

Now the part that makes the stereotype genuinely funny rather than merely false.

Poles are better at the drunken-Pole joke than anyone else alive. It is not close. Foreigners have a cartoon. Poland has a literature, a dictionary and a national repertoire, and all of it is sharper, filthier and more self-lacerating than anything a visitor has ever managed.

Consider what is codified in the actual PAN dictionaries, not folklore, not vibes, but headwords. *Kolega od kieliszka*: a person with whom close acquaintance rests on meetings at which alcohol is drunk. Polish has a dictionary entry for the friend you only have because you drink together. *Pic do lustra*, to drink to the mirror, meaning to drink alone. *Zalac robaka*,

to drown the worm. *Urwal sie film*, the film broke -- and grammatically the film is the subject and it breaks on you, in the dative, so that even the blackout is something that happens to a man rather than something he does. *Wchodzic miedzy wodke a zakaske*, to get between the vodka and the chaser, meaning to butt in: Polish built an idiom for interfering out of the drinking sequence itself. *Bez wodka nie rozbierzesz*, you cannot work it out without vodka, said of anything too tangled to understand sober, and it has nine registered variants, several in mock-Russian. *Trzezwij jak swinia*, sober as a pig, an anti-idiom that exists purely to be funny about the real one. And for the hangover, alongside plain *kac*, the WSJP offers *tupot bialych mew* -- the patter of white seagulls.

A country that has produced the phrase "the patter of white seagulls" for a hangover does not need a foreigner's help.

And then there is Pilch. *Pod Mocnym Aniolem*, 1999, Nike Prize, and the passage that ought to be printed on the back of every drunken-Pole joke ever made:

"Pili, bo Polska byla pod moskiewskim jarzmem, i pili w euforii po wyzwoleniu. Pili, bo Polak zostal papiezem... Pili, gdy byli sami, i pili, gdy ktokolwiek pojawil sie obok nich. Pili, kiedy Polska zwyciezala, i pili, kiedy Polska przegrywala."

They drank because Poland was under the Moscow yoke, and they drank in the euphoria after liberation. They drank because a Pole became Pope. They drank when they were alone and they drank when anyone at all appeared beside them. They drank when Poland won and they drank when Poland lost.

That is the stereotype, written better than any outsider has ever written it, by a Pole, in Polish, in a prize-winning novel, in a country that ranks eighth. The definitive statement of the national drinking myth was

composed inside the nation, for domestic consumption, as art. It is a costume, and the Poles keep it in the wardrobe and put it on for guests, and they wear it better than the guests do because they tailored it themselves.

The self-justification is just as old and just as knowing. *Nie my pierwsi obyczaj picia wprowadzili, pili Grecy, Rzymianie i Sarmaci pili*. We were not the first to bring in the custom of drinking; the Greeks drank, the Romans drank, and the Sarmatians drank. Four hundred years ago somebody was already doing the bit about how this is not really our fault, and doing it with a classical education.

Michal R. Wisniewski, writing in 2014 about gonzo journalism and its Polish practitioners, put the mechanism in one clause. Gonzo, he said, "makes such an impression on people, like, at last, some truth -- and it's never the truth." That is the whole architecture of the drunken-Pole joke. It arrives with the swagger of candour. It feels like somebody finally saying the unsayable thing. And it is a number that is eighth and falling, dressed up as a revelation.

The One Thing That Survives

None of which means the subject is harmless, and the book will say this once, plainly, and then leave it alone.

Between 1999 and 2022, Poland recorded roughly 79,000 deaths from alcoholic liver cirrhosis. Among men aged forty-five to sixty-four, the annual figure went from 436 to 2,583. Among women aged sixty-five and over, from 11 to 436.

That is the statistic that survives the debunking. It does not restore the stereotype -- it has nothing to do with national character, and countries

ranked well above Poland have their own versions of it -- but it is the reason none of this is a game. It is on the page. It stays on the page. We move on, because the man on the lift would.

What Is Left

So the lazy answer is gone. Bober does not drink beer at half past three because he is Polish. Polishness, measured in the only unit that measures it, puts him eighth in Europe, below Austria, and improving. If national character were the mechanism, the Romanians would be the punchline and the Latvians would be the folk tale, and the joke would have moved to Bucharest decades ago.

The stereotype was never a description. It was a costume, cut and stitched in Poland, sold abroad, and worn back home for laughs by people who own the pattern.

Which leaves the question exactly where Chapter 1 put it, only harder. A man on a boom lift, forty feet up, at a precise hour of a working day, opening a specific object. The reflex is real. The timing is real. The national explanation is a table with Poland in eighth place on it.

Somebody built this. Not the Poles -- the supply.

Six centuries of somebodies, in fact, and every one of them had a ledger.

What the Dues Did Not Take, the Vodka Took

The right to be the only bar in the world

In 1496 the Sejm passed a statute, and a Polish landowner acquired the exclusive right to produce and sell beer, gorzalka and mead within his own estate. A royal grant in 1572 widened it. By the seventeenth century it was ordinary, unremarkable, the way the countryside worked. The name for it is propinacja.

Read the terms slowly. They are better than any modern business plan.

The lord makes the alcohol. The lord owns the only place it may legally be sold, the karczma, where anyone else's alcohol is banned. The lord holds the import privilege too, so there is no legal route around him. His customers cannot leave the estate. He is also, in practice, the local court. And his income from propinacja often exceeded his income from every other activity on the land put together.

Not from grain. Not from timber. From the karczma.

Prince Czartoryski had a phrase for what he was looking at, quoted by Kacper Poblocki in *Chamstwo*: a real mint. Poblocki's own sentence is the one to keep, because it does the arithmetic on the whole arrangement. "Three hundred years of serfdom were also three hundred years of the consistent getting-drunk of the Polish people. Vodka became the most profitable branch of the lordly economy."

Nobody drifted into that. Somebody built it, wrote it down, and enforced it.

The quota, and the vodka left on the doorstep

Monopoly is half the machine. The other half has a Polish name that sounds like a tax code entry and works like a boot: *przymus propinacyjny*, the obligation on a peasant household to buy the alcohol produced on the lord's estate, and *przymus konsumpcyjny*, which fixed the annual quantity.

Three documented forms. You could not buy alcohol your lord had not made. Or you distilled your own and paid him by volume for the privilege. Or -- the version that should end any conversation about Polish drinking as a folk custom -- you had to take a set quota of vodka or *okowita*, and whatever you left was delivered anyway, poured out in front of your house, and charged to you.

The consequence recorded on the Polish side of the record is small and completely devastating. People in the countryside avoided holding weddings, because a wedding triggered an excessive vodka quota from the estate.

Sit with that. A peasant does not marry off a daughter this year, because the party is a taxable event and the tax is measured in litres. Reymont's line in *Chłopi* -- take a christening with water, drench a wedding with vodka, and a funeral with weeping -- reads as folklore. It is also a list of the three occasions on which estate revenue reliably spiked.

Karl Grolmann said it in one sentence, and it is the spine of everything that follows: *czego nie wydarto chłopu daninami, panszczyzna, odbierano pośrednio przez wodke*. What was not torn from the peasant by dues and corvée was taken indirectly through vodka.

Two collection systems, one peasant. The direct one took the grain and the labour. The indirect one sold the grain back as spirit and took the rest. There is no third pocket.

The fable, and who spread it

The propinacja right was often leased rather than run directly -- to village heads, innkeepers, and very frequently to Jewish *arendarze*, who worked the tavern and paid the noble his cut. This is where a lie has traditionally been inserted, and the book is not walking past it.

The fable is that calculated Jewish sobriety enabled a predatory monopoly over Christian peasants. It was propagated for centuries, and one of its busiest distribution channels was temperance-preaching Catholic clergy. The lie had a job: it moved the blame from the man who owned the monopoly to the man licensed to stand behind its counter.

Glenn Dynner took it apart from inside the archive in *Yankel's Tavern* (Oxford, 2014), documenting substantial Jewish alcoholism -- roughly five thousand *kvitlekh*, petition notes, in the YIVO holdings -- and showing the tavern as a place where Poles and Jews mixed rather than a trap set for one by the other.

The structure is what matters here. The noble held the right. The lessee carried the risk, the hours, and eventually the accusation. Clerical temperance and antisemitic scapegoating grew up entangled, and the tangle was useful to exactly one party.

The oath, and the petition against sermons

Here is the thing nobody who repeats the stereotype has ever heard.

Between 1844 and 1855, hundreds of thousands of Galician serfs took a public, solemn oath to stop drinking. In some districts as many as three quarters of the adults did it. Not a pamphlet campaign, not a resolution passed by a committee. Three quarters of the grown population of a district, standing up in front of each other and swearing off.

In the Prussian partition the Brotherhood of Sobriety had started in Silesia in 1844 around Fr Jan Alojzy Ficek, with papal approval from Pius IX in 1851. In the Russian partition from September 1858 the pledge took three quarters of the population of Grodno, Kaunas and Vilnius, and sales fell 33 percent in Grodno, 40 in Vilnius, 70 in Kaunas.

So the answer to "why do Poles drink" cannot be "because Poles want to." When the chance came, an enormous number of them publicly and collectively did not.

What happened next should be taught in schools.

The lords defended propinacja as, in their own words, a fixed, integral, indispensable part of their income. And they petitioned for a ban on sermons trespassing on the relation of serfdom.

The peasants organised against the drink, and the men profiting from the drink tried to make the sermons illegal.

In the Russian partition the same instinct arrived with an army attached. The finance ministry, in Mark Lawrence Schrad's account, "demanded that the Catholics renounce their temperance heresy and preach as the Orthodox did: that vodka was a 'harmless' and even 'necessary' indulgence." Taverns were attacked, troops deployed, protesters flogged and force-fed liquor through funnels. Over 780 people were tried before military tribunals and exiled to Siberia. Temperance societies were outlawed in 1863. (That the ban landed in the year of the January Uprising is our inference about what a state fears, not a published finding.)

A British journalist of the period wrote the sentence that survives all of it: "The teetotalers were flogged into drinking... These things sound incredible, but they are true."

Men were beaten for not drinking. Not in a folk tale. In the nineteenth century, with paperwork.

Three abolitions, because there were three partitions

Propinacja did not end. It ended three times, on three calendars, because Poland was being administered by three revenue departments.

Prussian partition, 1845. Galicia, 1889 -- where it effectively persisted anyway, and an 1905 law scheduled the real finish for 1911. Russian partition, 1898.

Half a century between the first date and the last, on land that is now one country. Which is why the alcohol-law map of the nineteenth century is still legible: those partition lines are the lines Szczerek is pointing at when he says Polska A and Polska B. Nobody redrew them. They just stopped being printed.

The mechanism, stated cleanly, in Russian

The clearest statement of how this machine works is about Russia, and it has to be labelled that way, loudly, because it is not about Poland at all.

Ivan the Terrible imported the *kabak* from Kazan in 1552. The Law Code of 1649 that bound the peasant to the land also banned selling vodka off it: one law, tying the man and his liquor supply to the same square of dirt. By the middle of the nineteenth century the monopoly ran to over a third of imperial revenue and covered 100 percent of the army's operating budget.

Schrad's conclusion: "Vodka became synonymous with Russian culture not because the Russian people demanded it, but because the Russian state supplied it." And the consequence for any government thinking of acting:

"If the state were to encourage the health and sobriety of its citizens, it would face immediate bankruptcy. The lesson was clear." Vasily Kokorev, most infamous of the tax farmers, named what the auctions really sold: "an exemption from the rules."

Schrad never wrote about Poland. Poland is not among the countries in his archival sources. The parallel here is ours and nobody else's, drawn because the Polish documents describe the same arrangement two centuries earlier at estate scale instead of imperial scale.

His cross-national table closes the last comfortable escape route: liquor taxes ran to 26 percent of state income in tsarist Russia, 25 in the United States, 23 in Britain, 20 in the German Empire, 15 in Sweden and Belgium, 11 in France and Norway, 9 in Switzerland and Austria-Hungary.

The United States. Twenty-five percent. Whatever this is, it is not a Slavic personality defect. It is what a treasury does after discovering a product that is cheap to make, addictive to buy, and hard to hide from a man with a ledger.

The word still painted on the shop

The Second Republic did not dismantle the logic, it nationalised it. The Panstwowy Monopol Spirytusowy was founded in 1924, and the state took over the business the nobles had run.

Which is why, a hundred years later, in a market economy inside the European Union, the ordinary Polish word for an off-licence is *sklep monopolowy*. The monopoly shop.

The monopoly is gone. The sign is not. Every Polish town centre carries a piece of 1924 in its windows, and nobody notices, the way nobody notices a fossil in a paving slab.

The shop that opened at ten and could sell nothing until one

The People's Republic ran the same instrument with the polarity flipped.

In the 1980s a rule banned alcohol sales before 13:00, while the monopolowy shops typically opened at 10:00. A shop selling nothing but alcohol, staffed, lit, unlocked, and legally forbidden to sell anything at all for the first three hours of its day. Somebody stood behind that counter every morning being paid to not do the only thing the building was for.

Then, from 13 December 1981, alcohol ration cards, inside a rationing system reaching a scope described as considerably wider than under the German occupation. Outsiders always get the mechanic wrong: the card did not buy the bottle. It only entitled you to buy the bottle. You still paid, in ordinary money, at the ordinary price. The state had found a way to charge full price for a permission slip.

Across the border the engineering was more exact still. A Soviet decree of December 1958 banned the sale of vodka by the glass, so drinkers were now forced to buy a whole bottle and go looking for chance companions. After the 1961 reform a half-litre cost 2 roubles 87 kopecks -- one rouble each from three men, 13 kopecks over. With no matching glasses they poured *po bulkam*, by the glugs. By the early 1970s vodka cost 3.62, the arithmetic broke, and the custom carried on anyway.

That ritual is Russian, not Polish, whatever the internet tells you. Poland had the whip-round and the wetting of a thing that had happened -- *oblewamy?*, so, are we dousing it? The point is not the ritual. The point is

that a finance ministry designed one by accident and people kept performing the design decades after the price that caused it stopped existing.

Kazik Staszewski put the whole PRL fiscal logic in one line: whoever does not drink vodka is a subversive, knowingly depleting state revenue, a man without ideals.

That is a joke. It is also the accounting.

The one time it was the workers who noticed

Jacek Moskalewicz wrote the Polish version of this thesis, about his own lifetime. "The Solidarity movement already had on its banners the alcohol question in the early 1980s. The working class apparently blamed the government for pushing alcohol to manipulate drunken society and to discredit its demands for a better life and freedom."

Alcohol supply, on the banners, next to the wages and the free press.

Out of those negotiations came the Act of 26 October 1982 on upbringing in sobriety and counteracting alcoholism -- still the governing law, the one banning alcohol advertising with beer carved out of it. By the end of the decade consumption had levelled off at around six litres of ethanol a head.

It worked. Which is why it was destroyed.

The reversal, which is the punchline

Moskalewicz again, on what happened after 1989: the control system was "totally rejected as a remnant of socialism, and most restrictions were lifted."

Licensing went to local councils, whose budgets were fed by the licence fees. Councils were now paid per outlet. Outlets went from around 40,000 in the late 1980s to more than 200,000 within a few years. The brewing industry expanded capacity and doubled, then tripled, consumption in under a decade. Drinking among 15 and 16 year olds doubled.

Then, in 2002, parliament cut excise on spirits by 30 percent. Spirits went from 1.7 litres of pure alcohol per head in 2002 to 3.4 in 2008. Zatonski and colleagues find that Poland's long post-communist health improvement halted in 2002, with alcohol-attributable mortality rising from 7.5 to 17.8 per 100,000 between 2002 and 2019, and 130,000 cumulative deaths from causes that are 100 percent alcohol-attributable across that span. 2019 alone: 10,396 people.

Schrad has one flattering paragraph about modern Poland -- spirits down from 61 percent of consumption at the fall of communism to 26 percent by 2002, male life expectancy up four full years, against a Russia going the other way. Those numbers are real. He stopped the clock in 2002, the exact year Poland cut the tax and turned around, and the Polish literature credits the earlier shift to a deregulated brewing industry rather than to any plan.

By 2023 the international assessment, from Rehm and colleagues in *Lancet Regional Health -- Europe*, was that Polish alcohol control had been "mostly dismantled."

The residue, in numbers: a Polish minimum wage bought 32 half-litre bottles of vodka in 2001 and 107 in 2021. There were 119,598 alcohol retail outlets in 2024, one for every 302 residents, in a country with one pharmacy per 2,700.

Nine to one against the pharmacy. Nobody voted for that ratio. It was assembled licence fee by licence fee by people whose budgets depended

on it -- a sentence that would have made perfect sense to a Galician landlord in 1780.

And now, the swing back

The machine is being re-tuned again, in the same way, from the same direction.

Krakow has banned night sales city-wide since 1 July 2023, and alcohol-related police interventions fell 48.5 percent in the first year and 61.8 in the second. Warsaw goes city-wide from 1 June 2026, 22:00 to 06:00, passed 57 votes to 2, sole exemption the airport duty free. Excise rose 5 percent on 1 January 2026 rather than the planned 15, because President Nawrocki vetoed the larger rise on 18 December 2025: "I cannot agree to an increase in excise tax introduced without time for entrepreneurs and consumers to prepare."

A total ban on all alcohol advertising, beer and 0.0 percent included, fines to a million zloty, cleared the Health Committee in July 2026 and awaits a second reading. It is not law. If it becomes law, an alcohol-brand mural becomes illegal -- worth holding on to, because somebody in this book paints walls for a living.

Which brings us back to the lift

None of this was Lukasz Bober's decision.

He did not sit in the Sejm in 1496, lease a karczma, or petition anybody to ban a sermon. He was not in Silesia in 1844 taking an oath, or in the Russian partition being flogged for keeping one. He did not found the monopoly in 1924, or stand behind a counter from ten until one forbidden to sell. He did not vote for the 30 percent cut in 2002. Nobody

has ever asked him how many shops per resident he would like, and nobody has asked you either.

What he has is a country where the word for the shop is still the word for the monopoly, the shop is closer than the pharmacy, the drink costs less against a day's work than it did when his parents were young, and six centuries of very competent people made very good money keeping all three of those things true.

So the can is within arm's reach on the lift at half past three. Of course it is. It has been engineered to be within arm's reach of a Pole for six hundred years.

The only free choice left in the whole apparatus is which can. And that one -- an American label on a beer brewed in Podkarpacie -- turns out to be a costume, and a lie, and the subject of the next chapter.

A Prize Nobody Won, A Muse Nobody Found

Read It Out Loud As A Document

Forty feet up, the wall two-thirds done, Bober holds the can out at arm's length and squints at it the way he squints at a colour he does not trust.

It is a document. Treat it like one. A blue ribbon on the front, which is a picture of an award. The date 1844, which is a founding, not a victory. A sentence, in the small heraldic type these sentences always come in, saying the beer was selected as America's best in 1893. And near the bottom, in four-point grey, the small print and the barcode, naming a brewery in Podkarpackie.

Four claims. The ribbon commemorates a prize that was never given. The slogan describes a competition that did not work the way the slogan says. The country of origin is a licence agreement. Only the founding date is true, and it is true about a company that no longer brews the thing in his hand. Every claim on that can is either a lie or a foreign address.

Bober knows none of this and it would not change his afternoon if he did. This chapter is about the two flattering stories attached to the object -- that it is a winner, and that it helps him make things -- and how both failed in the same way.

The Prize Nobody Won

Pabst tied real blue silk ribbons around the necks of its bottles from 1882. Actual silk, tied by hand. The Pabst Mansion puts the volume at one million feet of ribbon a year. It was retail decoration, a way of making a bottle look dressed the way a shop window is dressed, and it had been doing that job for eleven years before anybody held the fair the ribbon is now said to commemorate.

Now the fair. The 1893 World's Columbian Exposition awarded no ribbons at all -- not to Pabst, not to anyone. The judging was not a contest in the sporting sense: no head-to-head, no final, no runner-up. Entries were scored against a fixed written standard, and every beer scoring 80 percent or above received an identical bronze medal designed by St Gaudens. No gold. No silver. No grand prize. Pabst got the same medal as everybody else who cleared the bar, then marketed itself as though there had been only one.

This came from the 1891 contest rules and Bancroft's contemporaneous *Book of the Fair* -- the paperwork of the event itself, always there, never read against the advertising. When Dr Loih published it in 2017, the Pabst Mansion revised its website. So did the Wisconsin Historical Society. Two institutions whose entire function is to be right about Milwaukee had been repeating the beer's own press release.

And the sentence itself. "Selected as America's Best in 1893" was written in the 1950s, by a Pabst that was struggling and looking through its own attic for something to say. Sixty years separate the event from the claim about the event.

In order: the ribbon predates the prize by eleven years, the prize did not exist, and the sentence announcing it was composed six decades after the non-event, by people who needed a story more than they needed the

truth. Nothing here is a scandal. It is an ordinary piece of commercial fiction that hardened, the way a rendered wall hardens, into something everyone treats as load-bearing.

An Anti-Brand Is Still A Brand

The second story is better, because Pabst did not write it. Pabst found it.

In 1985 Paul Kalmanovitz bought the company for 63 million dollars, and his method was that of a man buying a dying animal for its hide: acquire fading brands, cut advertising to zero, cut quality control, milk the customers who would buy it anyway out of habit. The beloved fact that PBR does not advertise did not begin as a philosophy. It began as neglect with a spreadsheet behind it. By 1996 the Milwaukee plant was closed and Pabst was a "virtual brewer," a trademark with no brewery. By 2001 it was below a million barrels.

Then, in 2002, sales spiked in Portland, Oregon, with no marketing whatsoever behind them, and the brand manager Neal Stewart went to find out why. The turnaround was not designed. It was noticed. Somebody was already drinking the beer for reasons of their own, and a company out of ideas had the wit to go and ask.

What he found was a customer with a threat in his mouth. Stewart, 2004: "They literally said to us, 'I love your beer but the minute you advertise on TV, I'm done with you.'" And of the brand he inherited: "It was a forgotten brand with no marketing support."

So Pabst spent money on being absent. No TV, no NFL, no FM radio. Instead: bike messenger races, scooter rallies, kickball, fashion shows, and -- this matters here -- art exhibition openings, with beer and hats delivered to the gallery. Weekly quarter-page ads in the alternative papers of about

25 markets, each listing local bands and never the beer. MarketingSherpa called it slipping money in the manner of a sly uncle to these small events. Steve Nilsen, lifestyle marketing manager from 2009 to 2018, put the doctrine plainly: "We never told consumers -- ever -- what Pabst was: we let them decide for themselves." And: "Brands would pay big money to be at Coachella or South by Southwest or X Games. We were at all those events, but we didn't pay a dime to be there."

2002 was the first volume increase since 1978. 2003 was up 15 percent.

The company did not manufacture a meaning and broadcast it. It manufactured a vacancy and let its customers furnish it. A costume with the sleeves left unfinished, so the wearer takes them in himself and feels he tailored it.

Pabst Pays People Who Do Bober's Job

Since 2014 there has been the PBR Art Can Contest. Over 300 million 16-ounce cans have carried contest art; over 100,000 dollars has gone to emerging artists. The first winner, in 2014, was Josh Holland. The 2021 winner was Ashley Dreyfus, a mixed-media artist from Boise, whose design ran on more than 30 million cans. In 2022 Hannah Bunzey won against roughly 7,000 entrants from more than 120 countries.

Bober is a mixed-media artist.

The circle closes so neatly it feels rude to point at it. The beer's meaning is that artists like it, so the beer pays artists to design its packaging. The costume is crowdsourced from the exact people who will later be photographed wearing it -- a real commission with a real fee, which makes it both a decent thing to do for a painter's rent and the most

efficient advertising ever devised, because it is not advertising, it is a job. A brand whose entire proposition is that it does not sell to you has 300 million cans of other people's paintings in circulation.

Also, simply funny: Pabst has sold cases as large as 180 cans. Nothing to add. It is just the number.

Rakszawa, Wisconsin

Now the address.

The PBR that reached Poland was not shipped from anywhere. It was brewed in Poland, by Van Pur S.A., under licence from Pabst, at Rakszawa in Podkarpackie -- the country's largest independent brewer, five breweries, of which Rakszawa is the biggest at 1.75 million hectolitres a year. Van Pur's own line about that plant is glorious here: "Most of the beer brewed in Rakszawa is exported to highly demanding and distant foreign markets."

The launch was confirmed on 12 May 2020 by Tomasz Kopyra, Poland's best-known beer blogger: "kultowe piwo amerykanskich hipsterow, czyli Pabst Blue Ribbon juz nad Wisla w wykonaniu Van Pura" -- the cult beer of American hipsters, now on the Vistula, in Van Pur's rendition. In Van Pur's rendition. A cover version.

Pale lager, 4.7 percent, 500 ml, 3.99 to 4.59 zloty, in Polomarket, Carrefour, Frisco and Spar. Not import shops. The mainstream grocery aisle at the price of ordinary Polish lager, because that is what it is. The Polish beer press gave it 2 out of 10: "bardzo nieprzyjemny, slodki, landrynkowy jasny lager. Kukurydziano-miodowy." A very unpleasant, sweet, boiled-sweet pale lager. Corn and honey.

The same trademark in Germany runs about 3 euro for a 355 ml can -- 8.45 euro a litre. A York bottle shop sells it labelled "USA Trash Lager," which is at least honest about the purchase. And in China, Pabst sells "Blue Ribbon 1844": 720 ml, all-malt, reddish-brown, strong, dry-hopped with Cascade, aged in new uncharred American whiskey barrels, about 44 dollars a bottle, served with a champagne flute.

One trademark. Four class positions. A 44-dollar luxury ale, an 8.45-euro-a-litre affectation, a 4-zloty supermarket lager out of a Podkarpackie village, and a working-class signifier in Portland. The liquid is barely involved.

(Whether the Polish licence still runs in 2026 could not be confirmed, and the book will not pretend otherwise. What is solid: from 2020, PBR in Poland was Polish.)

Which is the title of this book and the joke at the centre of it. Bober is drinking Polish beer wearing an American costume. The most local possible object -- brewed by a Polish-owned company, sold in a Polish supermarket at a Polish price -- with the most foreign possible label glued to the front. Janusz, in Smarzowski's *Wesele*, on vodka: "Poniewierac ma, a nie smakowac." It's meant to knock you about, not to taste good. PBR fails that test deliberately, and the failure is the entire product.

The Costume Is Also On Fire

And the company selling it is going under. Pabst was the fifth-largest US brewer in 2024 at 3.1 million barrels across all brands, down 5.6 percent on 2023. In 2025 it cut 18 percent of its workforce, replaced its CEO and CFO, then cut another 60 to 70 people in December. The head office is being sublet.

A brand whose only asset was not being sold has spent a decade trying to sell itself.

The Muse Nobody Found

That is the medal. Now the other story -- the one Bober would actually defend if you pushed him at eleven at night -- which is that the beer helps.

There is a study for that. Everyone has read about it, or read about someone reading about it. Jarosz, Colflesh and Wiley, 2012, "Uncorking the muse," in *Consciousness and Cognition*, published as a Short Communication. Forty male social drinkers, twenty per cell, recruited on Craigslist, given 100-proof Smirnoff at 0.88 grams per kilo with bagels and a screening of *Ratatouille*, brought to a blood alcohol of 0.075, then tested on the Remote Associates Test: fifteen word-association items, one minute each. The drinkers got 0.58 correct against 0.42. $p = .001$. A large effect.

What the headlines left out: no placebo, no blinding. Every man in that room knew whether he had been drinking. And the much-repeated finding that the insights arrived as sudden flashes was marginal at $p < .08$; only a narrower count reached $p = .039$.

Then somebody ran it properly. Benedek and Zohrer, 2020, "Creativity on tap 2": preregistered, randomized, double-blind, placebo-controlled, $N = 125$, three groups at placebo, 0.03 and 0.06 blood alcohol. On the Remote Associates Test: $F(2,122) = 0.02$, $p = .98$. Not a small effect. Not a weak effect. A flat line. No effect on divergent thinking either, and -- awkwardly for the original -- no working-memory impairment, which was the mechanism Jarosz had proposed.

The authors' own summary: they "do not replicate previous findings reporting positive effects of alcohol on RAT performance," and "the empirical effect should be hard to miss in a well-powered study."

Two details finish it. The Remote Associates Test has an internal consistency of .45 and .46 and a retest correlation of .32 -- a very noisy instrument, the sort that throws off enormous published effects and then cannot find them again. And the null study was funded by the Dutch Beer Institute. A beer-funded experiment reporting that beer does nothing is not biased in the direction you would expect.

The Only Study That Ever Looked At A Picture

One experiment in the entire literature tested alcohol on a visual creative task rather than a word game: Lapp, Collins and Izzo, 1994, in the *American Journal of Psychology*. Balanced placebo design -- crossing what people actually drank with what they were told they had drunk -- on arranging pictures of wildflowers by colour, shape and number.

The most useful sentence in this chapter. There was "no pharmacological effect of alcohol on the creative combinations that subjects produced," but novelty was "enhanced when subjects thought they had consumed alcohol, whether or not they had actually done so."

The ethanol did nothing. The belief did the work.

Same shape as the ribbon. The object is inert; the story attached to it is the active ingredient. A blue ribbon certifies nothing -- it certifies because people agreed it does. A 4-zloty lager does not unlock associative thinking; it unlocks because the man holding it has read that it does.

Now the honest caveat, because a chapter that debunks has to meet the standard it enforces. The strongest version of the expectancy argument is

Kate Fox's: drunken comportment follows cultural expectation, not chemistry -- people behave the way their society has taught them drunk people behave. It is a good argument and it fits everything above. It also has to be said plainly that Fox's drink books were published by industry bodies -- the Portman Group in 1992, the Brewers and Licensed Retailers Association in 1996 -- and that the BBC disclosed her drinks-industry funding. Say it, do not bury it. And the counter-evidence is real: Bushman and Cooper, 1990, found that alcohol does cause aggression. Not expects. Causes. Ethanol is a drug and it does things.

It is just that none of the things it does is painting.

Nobody Has Ever Asked A Painter

A systematic Europe PMC search for experimental work on alcohol and visual artists returns zero studies. Not few. Zero. Everything in the literature is verbal -- word games you can administer with a clipboard. The people who stand on lifts have never been in a laboratory.

The closest anyone has come is Roe, 1946, reported through Ludwig, 1990: seventeen established artists, interviewed. All of them drank. "All but one avoided drinking while painting." None used alcohol to get past a technical problem. Ludwig's gloss is the whole argument in nine words: alcohol "provided the freedom for painting but impaired the discipline."

Seventeen painters. A tiny number, and the only number there is, and all of them said the same thing -- not that drink is evil, but that it is for afterwards.

And the slogan everybody quotes here is not even correctly attributed. "Write drunk, edit sober" is Peter De Vries, *Reuben, Reuben*, 1964, page 242, spoken by a fictional dissolute poet named Gowan McGland, and the

original is symmetrical and much less flattering to your evening: "Sometimes I write drunk and revise sober, and sometimes I write sober and revise drunk. But you have to have both elements in creation -- the Apollonian and the Dionysian, or spontaneity and restraint, emotion and discipline." It was pinned on Hemingway in a 2005 Usenet post to rec.woodworking. Hemingway, asked directly, said the opposite: "Have you ever heard of anyone who drank while he worked? You're thinking of Faulkner. He does sometimes -- and I can tell right in the middle of a page when he's had his first one."

The maxim is a half-sentence, amputated, wearing a dead novelist's name. It is the same object as the can: a real thing with a fake medal on it.

What Is Left

So: the ribbon is decoration promoted to a trophy in the 1950s. The beer is Polish. The company is cutting staff and subletting its own office. The study is a Short Communication with forty men and no placebo, and the replication came back at $p = .98$. The only visual experiment ever run found belief, not ethanol. The only painters ever asked said don't.

Both flattering stories are gone, and the joke was never on the man holding the can. It was on the story, written by people who needed him to believe it and who did not know his name.

But something is still happening at half past three. The light does go flat. The wall does stop being readable. He does stop, he does open it, and ten minutes later he goes back to work having decided something. That is not the ribbon and it is not the ethanol, and we have not named it yet.

It is smaller than a muse. It is also sadder, and better, and it is on the lift.

Ten Minutes Nobody Pays For

The Invoice

Start with the paperwork, because the answer has been sitting in the paperwork the whole time.

An exterior commercial mural in Poland is priced by the square metre. Two hundred to a thousand zloty per square metre, with the rate dropping toward the two hundred end once you are above a hundred and fifty square metres, because scale is a discount. A job over a hundred square metres starts at twenty thousand zloty. Works of art take eight percent VAT rather than the full rate, which means the tax authority has a category for this and the category is generous. Good Looking Studio, the market leader, will not publish a price list at all, which tells you the number is negotiable and that the negotiating is done somewhere the public is not invited.

Two things about those numbers before anybody gets excited on Bober's behalf. They are client-side contractor prices, not artist take-home: out of them come the paint, the lift, the licensed operator of the lift, the insurance, the assistants, and the months of design and permit work that nobody pays for separately. And Poland has no published muralist day rate. There is no interview anywhere in which a Polish muralist states their own fee. A trade that covers the sides of tower blocks in a country of thirty-seven million has left no public record of what it pays the person holding the spray can. Make of that what you like. The muralists apparently have.

What matters here is not the size of the number but the unit attached to it. The unit is the square metre. Not the day, not the hour, not the idea. Surface.

Everything the invoice recognises is a surface or a thing that touches a surface. A thousand square metre gable takes something like a hundred and seventy to three hundred and thirty litres of base paint for two coats, before a single line of the actual image gets sprayed. That is billable, and it should be, because paint costs money and somebody has to carry it. The podnosnik koszowy is billable, and so is the man in it, who must hold UDT certification, because the state has decided -- correctly -- that people forty feet above a pavement should be operated by somebody with a document. The season is billable in the sense that it constrains everything: acrylic facade paint wants plus ten to plus thirty, silicone will go down to plus five, and rain, wind, frost, humidity and hard direct sun all veto the day, which leaves Poland with an exterior painting season of roughly six to seven months. Half the year the wall is simply not available. That, too, is on the schedule, priced in as risk.

Now the other column. The looking is not billable. The deciding is not billable. The two months of drawings before anybody agrees on anything is not billable, and neither is the tour of permissions -- the owner or the wspolnota mieszkaniowa, then the city, then the konserwator zabytkow if the building is listed, then whatever the local uchwala krajobrazowa has to say about it. That can run months, and it runs at nobody's expense but his.

And the standing back and hating it is not billable. There is no line on any Polish mural invoice that reads: three-quarters of an hour, forty feet up, working out that the left side is dead.

What The Can Is Actually For

Here is where the book stops agreeing with everybody else in the file.

Every source that has an opinion about Bober and his beer is arguing about what the alcohol does to him. The romantics say it opens him up. The scientists say it does not. The scientists win, and they win badly. Lapp, Collins and Izzo ran the only alcohol experiment ever conducted on a visual creative task -- arranging wildflower pictures by colour, shape and number, which is not mural painting but is at least in the right sensory postcode -- and they ran it as a balanced placebo design, crossing what people actually drank with what people were told they had drunk. The finding, in their words: "no pharmacological effect of alcohol on the creative combinations that subjects produced," but novelty "enhanced when subjects thought they had consumed alcohol, whether or not they had actually done so."

The ethanol did nothing. The belief did everything.

Everybody who has quoted that result has quoted it as a debunking, and it is one, but they have all stopped one step too early. The interesting question is not whether belief is doing the work. It is which belief.

The assumed belief is: this will make me better. That is the belief the muse story requires, and it is the belief the replication crisis has been busy dismantling for a decade. But that is not the only thing a man can believe about a can, and on a lift at half past three it is not even the most useful thing to believe.

The operative belief is: I am allowed to not be working right now.

That is a permission, not a stimulant. And permission is the scarcest commodity on the entire job, because look at what else is on that lift. The paint has a temperature range and does not care about him. The weather has a veto and does not care about him. The lift has a certificate and a fuel

gauge. The client has a completion date. The wspolnota has opinions about the scaffolding blocking the bins. The season is closing at the far end of October whether the wall is finished or not. Every constraint in Bober's day is external, physical and non-negotiable, and every one of them is priced.

The can is the only object in the basket that answers to him. It is also the only object in the basket that is legible to everyone else. A man standing still on a lift staring at a wall is a man not working, and in a trade paid by the square metre, not working is the one activity with no defence. A man standing still on a lift with a beer in his hand is a man on a break. Same posture. Same forty feet. Same wall. Completely different accounting.

He is not buying inspiration. He is buying an alibi for the ten minutes the invoice does not mention.

The Worse Version Of A Free Thing

The argument has an ugly corollary and the book is not going to hide it.

If what he actually needed were the loose associative state -- ideas drifting sideways into each other, the left side of the wall suddenly rhyming with something he saw on a bus in 2019 -- there is a mechanism that reliably delivers that and it is free. It is REM sleep. Cai's people showed REM specifically improving performance on remote-association problems. Wagner's sleepers were more than twice as likely to spot a hidden shortcut in a task they had been grinding at awake. And Ebrahim's review of alcohol and sleep gives the trade in one sentence: "The onset of the first REM sleep period is significantly delayed at all doses."

At all doses. Not at drunk. At all of them.

So the drink buys an hour of a diluted version of what the night hands over for nothing, and then charges for it by postponing the night. This is the book's own inference and it has to be labelled as one: nobody has run the study. No experiment has tested the alcohol-versus-REM trade-off in creative work, and anyone who tells you otherwise is filling a gap with confidence.

But notice what the inference does to the muse story even unproven. If the beer were really about the associative state, it would be a bad instrument badly used, a man paying rent on something he already owns. That only stops being stupid once you accept that the associative state was never the purchase. The purchase was the stop.

Ludwig, looking at thirty-four heavy-drinking creative achievers over whole careers, found that alcohol directly decreased output in twenty-six of them -- seventy-six and a half percent -- and directly increased it in three. His own summary of the mess: "No simplistic conclusions are possible." Fine. Take the unsimplistic one. Over a career, the drink takes more than it gives. Over ten minutes on a Tuesday, it gives him the only thing on offer, which is the right to stand there.

A Language With A Word For Everything Except This

Polish is a language that names drinking with forensic precision, and the vocabulary makes the argument better than the argument does.

There is *kolega od kieliszka*, a dictionary entry, PAN's own, defined as a person with whom close acquaintance rests on meetings at which alcohol is drunk. Poland has a lexicalised term for the friend you only have because you drink together. There is *strzemienny*, the stirrup cup, the last round before the group disperses, historically served in a *kulawka* --

the lame one -- a glass with no base, which cannot be set down until it is empty. There is the living modern form of that same idea, *rozchodniak*, and its diminutive *rozchodniaczek*, which is a small affectionate word for the drink that is supposed to end the drinking. There is *oblewac*, to douse a thing, to wet an occasion. There is *zakaska*, from *kasac*, to bite: the bite that follows the swallow, named after its own timing.

Every one of those words exists because the culture needed to mark a boundary and used alcohol to mark it. The last one. The one that ends it. The one that turns *pan* into a first name. The grammar of the day, administered in glasses.

Now go looking for the Polish word for an hour of unpaid thinking about a job you are already being underpaid to do, and come back with nothing, because there is nothing. No dictionary has an entry for it. No invoice has a line for it. No client has ever asked for a quote on it. The single most important activity in making a wall that is not garbage has no name, no price and no social form.

So it borrows one. The can is not a muse and it is not a weakness. It is a receipt for time that has no invoice -- the only permission structure a man in this trade can carry up a lift in one hand.

The Joke Is On Him And He Knows It

By now Bober has read his own can, which is a thing this book has done to him and not for him.

The ribbon commemorates a prize nobody was awarded. The slogan about 1893 was written in the 1950s. The reputation for not advertising began as a man in 1985 deciding a dying brand was not worth the advertising money. The brewery that made the thing in his hand is at Rakszawa

in Podkarpackie, an hour and a bit from places he has painted, and Van Pur's own copy boasts that most of the beer brewed there "is exported to highly demanding and distant foreign markets." Whatever else is in the can, some of it came back.

Szczerek got to this shape first, and got to it harder. In Mordor a girl on a train points at the narrator's bottle and asks him why he is drinking impotence medicine so ostentatiously, in front of everyone. The prop is exposed as a joke on the man holding it. The chapter does not end with him putting it down. It ends with him handing it over: "Here. Drink up."

That is the correct ending and this book is going to copy it, because the alternative endings are all lies. Knowing the ribbon is fake does not move half past three by a single minute. The light still flattens. The colour still stops being judgeable. The invoice still has no line for looking. A false medal is a perfectly good excuse if what you needed was an excuse.

And there is a version of this where the beer wins and he loses, where the ten minutes becomes an afternoon and the afternoon becomes the reason the phone stops ringing and his liver files its own opinion; the Polish mortality tables have a column shaped exactly like a man his age, and this book is not going to pretend otherwise. That is the sentence. It has been paid.

What Szczerek also supplies is the refusal to be ashamed of the object, which is the last thing the argument needs. Every country makes icons out of its own space, he says, Americans with their roadside diners and their fire escapes, so why not here -- and culture.pl's gloss on the end of Siodemka is the whole position in nine words: it may be ugly but it's ours. Apply it to the can. A Polish lager brewed in a Podkarpackie village, sold in Polomarket at about four zloty, wearing the costume of an American beer that a British bottle shop labels USA Trash Lager and a Chinese

importer sells at forty-four dollars with a champagne flute. That is not a defeat. That is the most local possible object in the most foreign possible label, which happens to be an exact description of a Polish mural festival, a Polish supermarket, and a Polish artist on a Polish lift.

Mural Nie Istnieje

One more thing on the ledger and then we can leave him alone.

The wall is going to die. Not the paint's fault -- outdoor sacrificial anti-graffiti coatings last about a year, which is a maintenance schedule rather than a lifespan, and the paint underneath will outlive the coating for as long as the building stands. That is the problem. Walls in Poland do not die of weather. They die of demolition and of thermomodernisation, which is what it is called when a gable gets wrapped in insulation and a mural becomes something under the styrofoam.

Odzyski went up in Lodz in 2014, five artists, called one of the largest murals in Europe. The project page for it now says three words. Mural nie istnieje. The mural does not exist.

So here is the full accounting for the object Bober is making. It is priced by the square metre. The thinking that determines whether it is any good is unpaid. The season allows it to be made during roughly half the year. Its protective coating needs replacing annually. And its ultimate cause of death is a municipal insulation grant.

Against that, ten minutes.

Forty Feet

Half past three, and the light has gone flat the way it does, everything on the wall turning the same value, the reds and the greys agreeing with each

other for the first time all day, which is the eye announcing it is done and will not be taking further questions.

Two-thirds finished. The right side is doing what he wanted. The left side is not, and he has known that for about forty minutes, and knowing it and being able to name it are separated by exactly the interval that nobody is paying for.

He opens the can. It makes the noise. The ribbon on it is not a prize, the year on it is not the year, the address on the back is a village in Podkarpacie, and the beer inside got two out of ten from people who taste beer for a living. He knows all of it now. It changes nothing, because none of that was ever the job the can was doing.

The basket sways a little, the way they do. Down on the street somebody is trying to park badly. The lift operator with his certificate is on the phone to somebody about tomorrow. There are maybe two weeks left in the season and then the paint stops being legal against the wall.

He drinks, and he looks, and nobody is paying him for either.

The wall gets the ten minutes.